

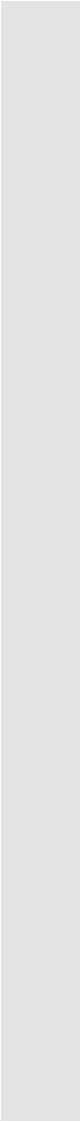
# Writing Seminar #2

Arranging Argument



# Components and Placement

When to say what you mean so you mean it the most.



## Overview:

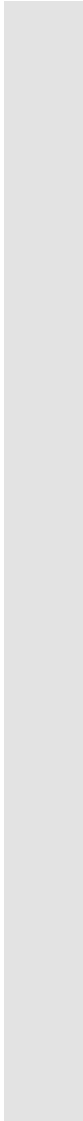
## What's in a paragraph?

- One single persuasive-yet-contestable claim.
  - Answers the question: what's the point of this paragraph?
- One or more supportive pieces of evidence.
  - Usually, a citation from the text.
  - Sometimes, a paraphrase of the text.
  - Rarely, a summary of the text. (Be careful!)
  - Extremely rarely, extra-textual information. (Be *extremely* careful!)
- Stated warrants.
  - Always: explain how your grounds relate to your main claim.
  - Sometimes: state common assumptions you expect your audience to share with you.
  - Never: explicitly declare warrants that will be unpersuasive.
    - If you find yourself working with unsympathetic or counterproductive warrants, likely you want to reconsider your claim!

## The Main Point

The huge, difficult, terrible and necessary question is:

Where should you place your main point?



# Non-academic point-last

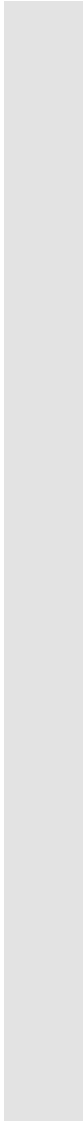
Example #1

(Don't) grab  
that cash

Investment banking is a business of building long-term relationships. Your job, as an investment banker, is to become close to the people who possess giant piles of money, in the hopes that one day they will do giant deals with their giant piles of money and give you some of it. If you are at the weekly meeting of an investment-banking group and everyone is going around the room talking about what they did last week, and someone says “I did a billion-dollar merger and earned an \$8 million fee for the bank,” and you say “I played Settlers of Catan with Mark Zuckerberg,” you win, because the expected value of proximity to a giant pile of money is so much higher than the value of an actual fee from a normal-sized pile of money. (Matt Levine, Money Stuff, 20 September 2021)

(Don't) make a  
stash

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# Academic point-first

Example #2



(Don't) grab  
that body

Achilles goes beyond the bounds of acceptable behavior in a different way. In Homer's text, heroes boast that they will allow the body of the vanquished to lie unburied and be eaten by wild birds and dogs; the boast somehow even adds to the *kleos*, or glory, of the victor. As is often pointed out, one key difference between the classical period and Homer's text is the classical institution of *anairesis*, whereby after a battle a truce was granted by the victors to enable the defeated to recover the bodies of their dead for burial. The classic case of the disastrous consequences of failing to bury one's own dead is the events of 405, when the Athenians won a naval battle at Arginusae but neglected to collect the bodies of some of their men. The generals in charge were put on trial and executed.

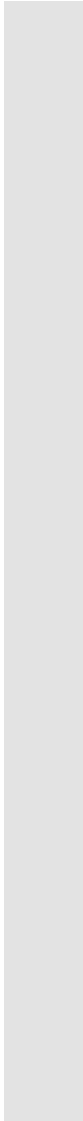
(Do) stash that  
body (in the  
ground)

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# Academic point-last

Example #3



and do and  
don't

The assumption of biblical philologists is that parallel syntax is alien to modern literary English is belied by the persistent presence of highly wrought paratactic prose even at the end of the twentieth-century. A variety of self-conscious English stylists in the modern era, from Gertrude Stein to Cormac McCarthy, have exhibited a fondness for chains of parallel utterances linked by “and” in which the basic sentence-type is the same structurally as that used again and again in biblical prose. What such a style makes manifest in a narrative is a series of more or less discrete events, or micro-events, in a chain, not unlike the biblical names of begetters and begotten that are strung one after another in the chains of the genealogical lists. The continuing appeal, moreover, for writers in our own age of this syntax dominated by “and,” which highlights the discrete event, suggests that parallel syntax may still be a perfectly viable way to represent in English the studied parallelism of verbs and clauses of ancient Hebrew narrative.

and don't and  
do

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# YOU HAVE AN ASSIGNMENT

Look for it in the posted document, check your Group's announcements for details about lead respondents, etc., etc.

